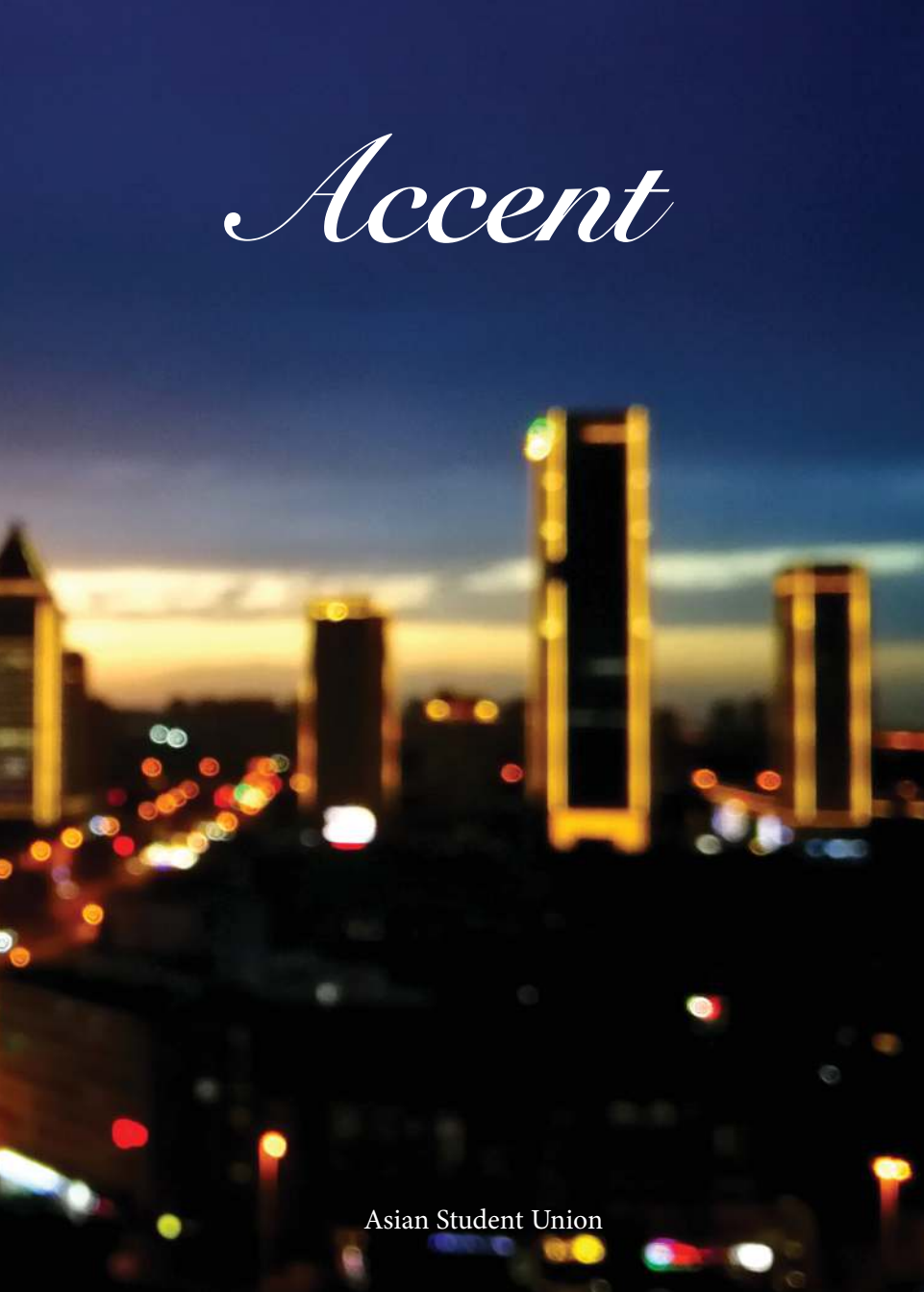
Accent



Asian Student Union

Accent

2024-2025

Issue 04

Editor-in-Chief
Divya Bhatia

ASU Heads
Divya Bhatia
Richard Zhu
Natasha Hearder
Josh Ho

Contributors
Divya Bhatia
Chun Cheung
Sophie Forbes
Ronit Goyal
Josh Ho
Janie Kim
Kadence Sun
Daisy Wang
Josephine Xie
Richard Zhu
Yolanda Chen
Marc Dahlhoff
Riya Goyal
Natasha Hearder
Connie Kang
Amanda Meng
Jessica Tian
Yiru Wang
Kaz Yamada

Brought to you by the Asian Student Union

Accent

Accent tells the stories of Asians and Asian Americans living in the United States. As the word “accent” means a distinctive way of pronouncing words in a certain language by putting emphasis on a particular syllable, we strive to show the diverse and distinct nature of being Asian by putting emphasis on personal stories.

Brought to you by the Asian Student Union, Accent invites everyone to get a glimpse of what it means to be an Asian in 21st century America. By sharing our voices, we become more resilient and powerful. Creativity is our way of empowering each other.

The Asian Student Union at St. Andrew’s School is a safe space for all students who identify as Asian. We strive to unite and empower through cultural and educational avenues.

Letter from the Heads

Dear Reader,

I have had the amazing opportunity to create and edit the fourth edition of the Accent magazine. It has been my honor to endorse the power of our diverse identities while it being an amazing learning experience. Being impacted by these stories has made me reflect on how my South Asian identity defines who I am. The power of the arts and literature depicted in this magazine causes you to see how people can express themselves in various perspectives. This magazine is made to strengthen that connection between us all as you flip through all the hard work expressed here.

It has also been a pleasure to serve as an ASU Co-Head this year and I can't wait to see how far we go in the future. From our ramen function to SAISL to Crazy Rich Asians, we have come together in countless ways. I am so glad I have two more years with this affinity group and I know that each year will only get better. However, to the seniors graduating, please know that there will always be a place for you at ASU. This union will only grow into a more fun and inclusive group, and I can't wait to see where it goes for as long as I can.

As you look through the 2024-2025 edition of the Accent Magazine, you should see the pride our community holds in all the endeavors we accomplish in regard to our Asian identity. With so much talent, I am proud to say that I am of Asian descent and we all should be too. The various depictions of our lifestyles show how we thrive in our community and in the world by being ourselves. I hope you enjoy this edition of the Accent Magazine and find pieces of those lifestyles that resonate with you!

Sincerely,
Divya Bhatia '27
Co-Head & Editor in-Chief

Dear Reader,

It was truly a dream-come-true experience for me to serve ASU as the Co-Head for 2024-2025. From the very first time that I stepped into this school, leading ASU through connecting with other Asian members of this community has always been a huge dream. From the ramen function to cooking dumplings in Gahagan, I am incredibly proud of how far ASU has grown. Therefore, I want to present my most sincere gratitude to every member of ASU, and I want to give my warmest appreciation to Divya, Natasha, Josh, and Profe for all they do to make this union the most meaningful it can be.

I always believe that trust and love go both ways. Throughout the many months we have been together in this school, I continuously sense the

deep commitment that every ASU member makes for this group to be a true space for connection and love. The trust and love that we hold for each other always inspires me to keep going, and in return, I promise to give my trust and love to every single one of you as well.

What makes ASU a great affinity group is not complicated; it only requires these two things from each one of us—be true to ourselves, and be true to other members of this affinity group. As you look through this magazine, I would encourage you to continue reflecting on this idea of trusting yourself and trusting others who share a common background as you do. I look forward to seeing you all next fall!

Sincerely,
Richard Zhu '26
Co-Head

Dear Reader,

It has been an honour to provide and represent for Asian Student Union as a fellow Co-Head this year. Truthfully, I was somewhat scared to join the ASU functions as a freshman—not knowing how welcoming this community truly is. From our wins in SAISL to functions in the classroom, one can always feel the vibrance looming in the community. My freshman-year self definitely would not have imagined myself later running the same community I was once hesitant to be a part of. I could not have asked for a better year with this group, or better co-heads to lead and work with. Thank you Divya, Josh, and Richard for always putting so much effort into the group and being such easy people to work with!

I hope everyone enjoys this year's edition of the Accent Magazine and appreciates all the work our fellow classmates have put into their pieces. The SAS ASU community has a lot of vibrance and culture to offer, and I am so thankful everyone else can be a part of it too.

I can't wait to continue my journey with ASU next year and enjoy this year's edition of the Accent Magazine!

Sincerely,
Natasha Hearder '26
Co-Head

Dear Reader,

It has been a pleasure to serve as an Asian Student Union leader this year. I am grateful to have been an Asian Student Union leader this past year, but it has had its bittersweet moments. From my last Asian

Sensation SAISL game, ramen function, to watching Crazy Rich Asians, each function has provided itself with opportunities to connect. Through and through it has been a blessing to be able to connect with different asian experiences. I am confident that the upperclassmen will continue to help new students find their home. I know that the leaders next year will continue to flourish, and I can't wait to see what they have planned.

As you look through the magazine we hope that you can see the variety of talents displaying different cultures and experiences. The upperclassmen will continue to thrive and display their abilities throughout school next year. Although my time is up, I know that this group is in great hands with the other leaders and the rising underclassmen. I am grateful for these past three years in the Asian Student Union. I keep all of the memories close to my heart and I don't regret one moment with you all.

Happy AAPI month and enjoy this year's version of the Accent Magazine!

Sincerely,
Joshua Ho '25
Co-Head

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Diwali Chapel Talk

Ronit Goyal '27

You know initially, I didn't really enjoy Diwali. This might come as a surprise, but I thought it was too tedious and time consuming. I didn't like wearing my traditional outfits for hours at a time nor taking, what seemed like, millions of photos. I was easily bored with the mantras. I didn't even know what they were saying, I just followed along with my parents. Honestly, the only times that I enjoyed Diwali was when it used to fall on my birthday.

I knew the stories of how Diwali was created. Lord Ram fights Ravan, the demon king, in order to save his wife Sita, whom Ravan kidnapped earlier. After Ravan is defeated, Lord Ram and Sita return to their home, Ayodya. This recount is an oversimplification, though the essence of the story is a celebration of Lord Ram's triumph over evil, and being resilient throughout all of his troubles.

Mythology is an interest that I have always been curious about. I mean, these are stories that we have very little, if not no evidence for, and yet we still talk about them today. I learned about Indian mythology throughout my childhood. The Ramayana, the full story of Lord Ram, was a common choice for TV show producers. I still see reenactments today.

My mom explained these stories to me as a kid. Each part has significance and relevance to one another. I was intrigued by the works of Lord Ram in relation to other Hindu gods. I would cross reference what I had learned from my mom and other written books to these TV shows. Occasionally, the TV shows would be a little out of script, but for the most part, I tied it all together. I learned that the mantras that we sang, are the stories itself of each god that the mantra was dedicated to. I learned that there are chapters to each part of mantras like a book. There would be a chapter where as a kid, I got to break, sorry, I got to attempt to break a coconut outside, which is a key tradition. I still failed like 90% of the time, but it was still fun to attempt to do so and knowing what that means to Diwali. Spending time with my mom learning about why I even sang what I sang during Diwali kept me engaged for the future celebrations we did. The length of time that I used to despise before, got a little more manageable with every celebration.

The shrine that my family makes has numerous parts to it. The idols themselves have to be decorated. Rugs and other seating arrangements are to be made for other guests. Items like diyas and flowers have to be set up. Materials like powders and milk need to be situated properly around the shrine. To say the least, I did not want to help make this nor did I want to help clean up after. Unfortunately for young me, I didn't have a choice. My dad enlisted me to set up the shrine. However, I learned the 'why' aspect of what I was doing.

The haldi (turmeric) and kum kum (you know the red dot on our foreheads, yup, that) powders are an auspicious mark for the person wearing it to be blessed. The coconuts that I mentioned earlier were a sign of opening one's heart, and drinking the coconut water was purifying you. The holy food, or prasad, is believed to be blessed. Some of the jobs my dad taught me were how to clean the idols properly, how to decorate the shrine, and how to crack coconuts. Over time, with more knowledge of what I am doing, I have come to enjoy setting up and decorating the shrine. I consider it as a blessing, since I get to set up once with my dad and learn more. I once called it tedious, but spending time with my dad and learning of the impact of the shrine on Diwali has again, made it a little more manageable with every celebration.

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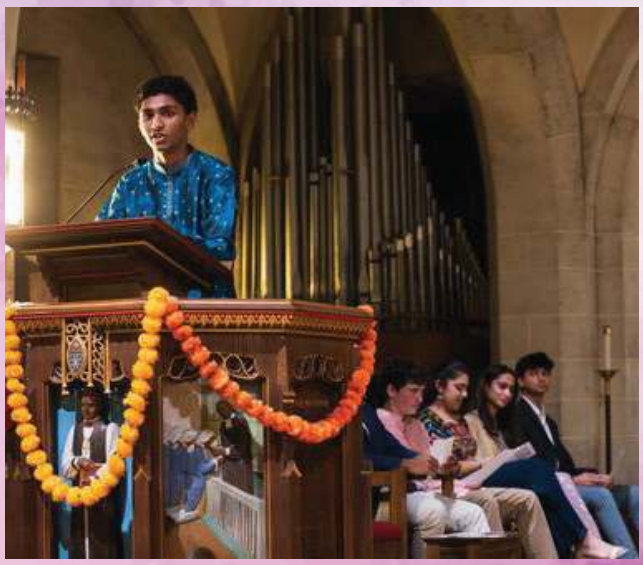
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Diwali is the bright light of the Hindu calendar, shining a path for me to look forward to. When I was young, I didn't see the dancing flames of diyas or happy feelings of being with friends and family. Rather, I saw the time consuming preparations and endless work. Diwali has shone brighter every year that I have celebrated. It is a reward or a blessing that I have been given. Just like how Lord Ram and Sita came back to joy-filled Ayodhya with festivities, I consider coming back and celebrating Diwali as joy and rewarding. The only difference is Lord Ram fighting a war and I am fighting the urge to sleep in study hall.

I want you to think of your own cultural connections you may have. Diwali may be unique to my culture, but each of us has something that connects us to our roots and values. Embracing these connections allows us to share a bit of our light with others. Mythology was a part of my culture that I connected with. It brought me closer and gave me a better understanding of Diwali.

For each of your cultures, cherish the moments it creates. Appreciate your own culture and be curious about it. These meanings are a part of you and there is always a reason as to why you and your family perform certain traditions. Make an effort to participate in these traditions as it can reveal information you may be curious about or answer some of your own questions. It can help you feel more positively about a festival.

I would like to wish you all a very prosperous Diwali filled with love, happiness, and success. May the goodness of goddess Lakshmi come to your homes and enrich your life. Happy Diwali!





Art by Riya Goyal ’27

That Wooden Dock

Richard Zhu '26

From the very first day and the first breath I chose to take,
I gently stepped onto that wooden dock between the land and the lake.
The sky veiled in blue as the cold morning breeze prickled my face;
I pondered anxiously, "Who should I be, amidst this distant place?"

Sometime later, I gently stepped onto that wooden dock between the land and the lake, once again.
Together, I brought along some friends with whom my journey began.
I pondered anxiously, "Who should I be, amidst this distant place?"
while the green ripples and the faint afternoon sunbeam watched over our youth and this space.

I brought along some friends with whom my journey began;
We laughed, we played, and we teased life as we let our hearts fly as far as we can.
While the green ripples and the faint afternoon sunbeam watched over our youth and this space,
I realized and thought to myself, “I ain’t gonna change a thing to be who I call ‘me’.”
We laughed, played, and teased life as we let our hearts fly as far as we can.
The forest and the white clouds approved us in tranquility while the wind, who towards our future, ran.
I realized and thought to myself, “I ain’t gonna change a thing to be who I call ‘me’.”
On that wooden dock, I am as delighted and free as I can be.

The forest and the white clouds approved us in tranquility while the wind, who towards the future, ran,
from the very first day and the first breath I chose to take.
On that wooden dock, I am as delighted and free as I can be.
Now, the sky burned in red as the warm sundown breeze softened my face.



Photo by Connie Kang ’26



Blossom and Border

Josephine Xie ’27

Beneath a cherry blush of foreign springs,
I trace the sun’s gold script on unfamiliar bark,
watch petals falling, taking flight
while roots, half-buried, whisper in the dark.

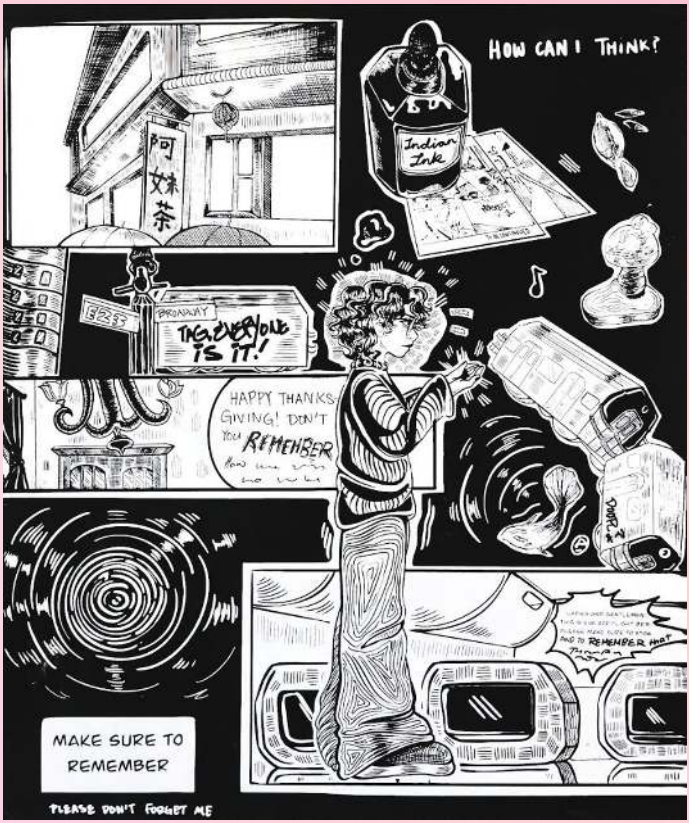
I wear this new spring like a borrowed coat:
too stiff at the seams, too bright against my skin.
My shadow splits: one strides on this land,
one hedged between busy silhouettes on the streets.

The air hums warm, a lullaby of bees,
yet in this thaw, a chill persists
the scent of plum blossoms, slow-cooked memories,
like a voice that lingers in the wind.

The world here softens, green and fresh,
yet when the dusk spills ink across the sky,
I count the stars that once lit above Grandma’s lane
their names, like hers, are not quite the same.

I wonder why a heart can hold two seasons in one beat:
the here and there, the almost and the near.
I bloom in transient soil, bittersweet:
a hazy split, half-homesick, half frontier.

Spring stretches, kind, to mend what time untethered,
but home is a flavor no new sun replicates.
I carry both: the sun and the rain, tethered
for a self made world.



Art by Sophie Forbes ’25



Art by Janie Kim ’26



Photo by Yiru Wang ’25

Lunar New Year Chapel Talk

Yiru Wang '25

At 7:32 p.m. in my hometown Tianjin, the weather forecast began. I never knew fog could have so many nuances, nor did I care. But my grandma sat on the edge of the couch, her gaze fixed on the TV as if the fate of her tiny apartment depended on the rain patterns in distant provinces. I fidgeted beside her, stealing glances at the clock on the wall. The Lunar New Year Gala started at 8. I was 28 minutes behind the moment I was waiting for, though it felt like a lifetime.

Growing up, Lunar New Year was never a parade of lanterns or the deafening crackle of firecrackers that lit up city streets. It was the quiet rhythm of three people—me, my mom, and my grandma—gathering in a space that felt both too small and just right. My mom stir-fried dinner in the kitchen, and I sat next to my grandma on the couch, counting down the minutes, waiting for a tradition I didn't yet understand.

Dinner was always simple. A steamed fish lay at the center of the table—a symbol of good luck that I hated the taste of. "Eat it," my mom would nudge, her chopsticks hovering over the fish's tail.

But I always calculated my way around it, stacking celery, tofu, and mushrooms on my plate as if they could shield me from her insistence. By the time the gala began, my impatience had boiled away. I watched the magic tricks, laughed at the skits, and tuned out the songs until sleep overtook me long before the midnight dumplings.

I never made it to the new year. I was always asleep, hours behind.

Then I came to the U.S. for school, and time itself seemed to shift beneath my feet. Lunar New Year arrived at 11 a.m., unmarked by firecrackers, festive chatter, or the comforting hum of my grandma's ancient TV. My freshman year, I found myself sitting on the stairwell of dorm, laptop perched precariously on my knees. The New Year's Gala streamed live, a faint echo of home carried by pixels and poor Wi-Fi. I watched the countdown, the fireworks illuminating my screen instead of the night sky. For the first time, I was awake when the year turned.

But it wasn't triumph I felt. It was emptiness—a hollow echo, as if I had slipped through the cracks of my own tradition.

By lunch, the dining hall was bustling, trays of chicken tenders and fries clattering onto tables, the room alive with conversation that was utterly indifferent to the holiday I was holding in my heart. In Tianjin, my grandma would already be asleep.

My mom would be wiping down the table, the scent of sesame oil and vinegar still lingering in the air. I was 13 hours behind the life I once lived.

"Maybe when we retire, we'll visit you in America for Lunar New Year," my mom told me over the phone. I nodded, knowing it wouldn't be the same. Dumplings made in a foreign kitchen wouldn't carry grandma's deft touch or the history folded into each pleat. A midnight countdown in this time zone wouldn't echo the one I used to sleep through, no matter how many firecrackers I imagined.

I will always be 13 hours behind for the Lunar New Year, away from my family.

Yet, at St. Andrew's, a new kind of family emerged during Lunar New Year. Chinese parents of my classmates would visit campus, and the dining hall transformed, tables laden with dishes that bore only a faint resemblance to my grandma's cooking. None of the dumplings had fillings of my grandma's secret recipe, but they were warm and familiar in a way that transcended taste. Snacks that my mom had always forbidden made their way into my hands. These were foods foreign to my childhood Lunar New Year, but somehow, they tasted like home. Friends laughed as we crowded around plates piled high with food, and I found myself savoring not just the dishes, but the moments—the warmth of being surrounded by people who understood the ache and joy of celebrating far from home.

I've come to realize that "13 hours behind" isn't just about time zones. It's the chasm between what I had and what I'm building. It's the sum of every lost moment and the ones I've yet to create, a bittersweet arithmetic that forms the rhythm of my life now.

This Lunar New Year, I'll sit with friends who won't understand the significance of the steamed fish I skip, but who will laugh and eat with me anyway. And when the clock strikes twelve, I'll whisper my countdown into the stillness, letting it ripple across time like an unseen thread. In my mind, I'll hear the crackle of firecrackers reverberating through Tianjin's narrow streets. I'll see the faint glow of the weather forecast illuminating my grandma's face. I'll smell the sesame oil on my mom's hands, lingering long after the dishes are done.

Because even 13 hours behind, I carry Lunar New Year with me—not as a relic of the past but as a bridge to the future. It lives in every bite of a dumpling, in every memory stirred by the scent of sesame oil, in every imperfect fold of a tradition I am learning to make my own. Even with 13 hours behind, I am not lost; I am a thread stretching across time, binding the past and present into something unbroken.



Photo by Richard Zhu '26

PRISM Chapel Talk

Kaz Yamada '26

Like many of you, I'm a student. An athlete. Every Thursday I attempt to play the right notes during Orchestra, but it typically doesn't go very well. I overthink things quite often, I get really nervous about tests and assignments that I probably shouldn't, I laugh at jokes that aren't funny, and I also might eat too many cookies during Advisory lunch. I stay up too late doing homework I should've started earlier. I miss home sometimes, even if I pretend not to. I've failed tests, I get marks for missing breakfast check-in, and I remember my laundry in the washer 2 days later. In other words, I'm not that different from you. But there's one part of me that tends to change the way people see me. I also happen to be gay. And the thing is, I wish that last part didn't always come first.

Being gay at a place like St. Andrew's, especially living on dorm and being in the locker room, you learn pretty quickly to monitor how you act. You don't want to make anyone uncomfortable. You don't want to be "too much" and be labeled as "too gay". You laugh at certain jokes and shrug off others. You wonder if people avoid you because of who you are. You walk into a room full of straight guys and you can feel the shift.

Not always. Not with everyone, but sometimes it's like suddenly there's this filter over you: everything you say, everything you do, is through the lens of being gay. When I talk about boys while they talk about girls. When I make the same joke as someone else, yet it lands differently. When I sit down on someone's bed or in the common room and they move away: I start to wonder why they don't do that when someone else does the same. And I can't help but think: Would this be different if I wasn't gay? Would my life be easier if I was straight?

Don't get me wrong, I'm not ashamed of who I am, in fact I'm proud, but what gets heavy is that for a lot of people, especially other guys my age, the minute they find out I'm gay, it's like that becomes the only thing they see. One of the hardest parts is that people don't always realise they're doing it. The judgement isn't loud, it's quiet. It's in the sideye and the "oh" after I say something about a guy. It's in the careful distance on my bed. It's not being in on certain jokes or being picked last during a dodgeball dorm function.

Suddenly I'm not the same kid they swam with in the pool or the rower they raced with on the water. I'm not the guy who likes singing or the guy that listened to them when they needed an open ear. I'm not the friend they were joking with past lights out. I become the gay kid. And when that happens, everything changes. They start watching their words around me like I'm going to be offended by everything. They stop sitting next to me like I'm going to hit on them or something.

They laugh nervously when I talk about who I think is attractive. They act like being around me means they have to change who they are. But all I want—what so many of us want—is to just be normal. To just be. I want to be able to talk about things I like without the fear of judgement.

I didn't choose to be gay. But I do choose who I am beyond that. I choose to show up every day to classes and meetings. I choose to try hard in school and my studies. I choose to put in extra effort at practice even when I'm exhausted. I choose to be there for my friends, to give them a hug when they feel down, to hype them up when they're winning. But sometimes it feels like none of that matters as much when the label comes first.

St. Andrew's is intense. Living in Founders, we live where we study, where we eat, where we make connections, where we sleep. This means we have to make this place feel like home, even when it's hard. And it's hard to feel at home when people only see one part of you. I wish more people understood that I'm not walking around thinking about being gay 24/7. In fact, I have so many other things to be thinking about. I'm probably thinking about how I'm going to bomb my quiz on moles, or what a derivative is, or how I'm not going to fall sleep during Research Sem. Sometimes it feels like I have to carry around this invisible sign that says: "Don't worry. I'm gay, but I don't like you and I'm not trying to make it awkward, I'm just trying to talk to you."

There was this one time, I remember it so clearly, I was hanging out with a group of guys in their room after classes and we were playing brawl stars. We were joking around, talking about our classes, and just about the overall feeling of the semester. For a second, I felt totally in the group. Just another kid, just another guy. And then one of them got killed, got mad, said something small, something dumb about "this guy definitely likes boys" and then he looked at me and went dead silent. Everyone did. I could feel the air shift. The awkwardness, the immediate realisation of what he said, the subsequent "oh my bad". But it continues to happen, hearing the frequent "that's so gay" or talking in a high pitched voice and acting feminine when describing someone they might think is gay.

But the truth is, I'm tired. Tired of being treated like a walking billboard for gay people. I wish people would understand this: Being gay isn't the most interesting about me. It's not even in the top five. I'd rather talk about how I can't whistle and wish I could. Or how hard it is to be a bears fan. Or how much I love listening to Bruno Mars. I want to be seen, really seen, for all the things I am. Because when we lead with labels, we put people into a box. We assume things about them, we miss their stories. And when we treat someone like they're only the parts that make them different, we forget how much we have in common.



Art by Yolanda Chen ’27



Art by Chun Cheung ’27

Always Met with Anger, Never Satisfied

Joshua Ho ’25

Always make fun of our Asian accent,
And “Ching-Chong” us and make eye gestures.
The “Chinese virus,” the blame placed on us,
What is there to do? When will the pain stop?

Always trying to be normal and try
To be “real” Americans. Never
Able, we don’t belong and don’t fit in
You demean us screaming “leave go back home”
Always met with silence still after more
Hate-crimes even after the spa shooting.

Crying for change, my ancestors still say we
“Shouldn’t speak up we’ll be an embarrassment”
We must stand and speak up it can’t persist

International

Natasha Hearder ’26
Marc Dahlhoff ’26

It’s okay to miss home once in a while,
Nostalgia hits at the most random times.
The path can be blurry and filled with detours,
Eventually you’ll adjust to yours.
Rising beyond—roots of the homeland,
Not always do others understand.
All suddenly strange and weirdly new,
This part of the journey: a reality, too.
Integration at (this magical/an international) place,
Our cultures, here, defy the limits of race.
Never let fear dictate where you go;
Abroad we study, abroad we grow,
Loving St. Andrew’s eternally so.



Photo by Connie Kang ’26

Waiting for Bamboo Shoots

Kadence Sun ’27

Every year, we would open the highest cabinet, taking turns standing on tiptoes, our gaze searching for a single piece of worn yellow paper locked in a rigid glass frame. A battered enamel jar would sit off to the side, filled to the brim with fermented bamboo shoots, your favorite food because there is something special about it that makes you come back for it despite its putridity. The days when Grandma would tread miles of mountain dirt to dig the bamboo up, you would sit and watch and wait. Waiting for the sound of her sandals crunching the dry earth, for the sight of her basket overflowing with muddy lumps, always fresh, must be fresh, otherwise, you would throw a tantrum, not noticing the sag of her shoulders and the lines of the basket’s weight etched into her skin. Watching for the bamboo to be free of a single speck of dirt, cleansed with cold spring water until Grandma’s hands turn red and turgid. A smile of reassurance masks her pain, with her melodic voice singing “I’m alright, it’s just water,” though you never ask how her hands are holding up. Waiting for the bamboo to ferment in the air-tight jars, waiting for Grandma to cook your favorite rice noodles with them, seal her love in a battered enamel jar, and then?

Then you would wait some more, wondering why it takes so long for a silver-haired, tiny-footed figure to stumble across meandering, mired roads to bring it to you. You wait till the other students disappear into the cafeteria, carrying fancy lunch boxes handed out to them by parents whose shirts glint white under the

sun. When she finally arrives, you guide her to the most inconspicuous corner of your school campus because the journey stained the rim of her patched-up pants the shade of a rainy day in the mountains. As grandma straggles after you, her hunched back protruding from the rest of her haggard body, your cheeks flush with the hue of the pomegranate juice she wrapped in Saran. You waited—to take a photo of her and remember her, and you didn't realize that perhaps you waited for too long, because one day she never showed up, and before you could snap a picture of her sunken face, she had returned to the last embrace of the mountain. Now you wait for your turn to stare into the glass frame that holds the worn yellow paper with her name on it, the absence of her photo is a void you can't lay your eyes on, and you don't have to wait long for the foul smell of fermented bamboo shoots to fill the air, mingling with the salt of your tears.



Digital Art by Jessica Tian ’27

Unboxed

Divya Bhatia ’27

They look at me and assume they know—
Spice, smart, and an upbeat dhol.
But when I dance Bhangra, it’s not a show,
But rather the girl who finally feels whole.

My name is Divya—it means divine light,
But some days, it’s hard to feel that bright.
Still, it holds piece of home in each letter,
And I carry it hoping I’ll grow into it better.

They wrinkle their nose at the smell of my chai,
But they ask for a sip when the weather runs dry.
There’s memory steeped into every cup,
Cardamom stories they’ll never pick up.

People are constantly trying to figure out my race,
As I am too brown or too foreign for some.
My hands hold my languages, rhythm, and grace,
Rooted in both here and the place I am from.

Unboxed, I’m still becoming each day—
Not neat, not soft, not folding away.
Call me what you want, I’ll still rise,
Feet to the drum, fire in my eyes.

Art by Riya Goyal ’27



Lunar New Year Chapel Talk

Connie Kang ’26

In honor of the Chinese new year, I want to share a concept deeply rooted in Chinese art and philosophy: leaving blank.

In Chinese paintings, the blank areas—areas where no brush touches the canvas—are just as important as the detailed ones. At first glance, those blank spaces might seem like unfinished gaps. But if you’ve ever admired a traditional Chinese painting, you know the blank areas are anything but meaningless. They create depth, emphasize the main subject, and provide balance. They guide the viewer’s eye and allow the painting to breathe. Without the blank spaces, the painting would probably feel overcrowded, chaotic, and unclear.

My chapel talk might feel like a cliched comparison—drawing a life lesson from an artistic technique. But sometimes, the most common ideas resonate the most because they hold real truth. This concept, when applied to life, has a surprising depth that’s worth exploring. So I hope you’ll take a few moments with me to reflect on it.

We live in a world that often glorifies the status of being busy. We are pressured to fill our schedules with activities, our minds with thoughts and ideas, and our lives with accomplishments. Sometimes, we try to solve every problem or answer every question immediately. But when we do so and leave no room for blank spaces, life can be overwhelming and our purpose gets lost in the chaos.

Each year, as our workload significantly increases, we lose our sense of direction in the assignments, essays, and tests. I always felt pressured to do work during my free block, on Sundays, during long lunches when I don't have community service, and pretty much every single blank piece of time I own··· Otherwise I would feel like I am wasting precious time. Everytime I sit down and enjoy something, like watching a movie or hanging out with friends, I can't help but be distracted by the idea of 'I could do something else more productive right now', and thereby ruin that moment. This idea has stayed with me, until after an experience I had during finals week last year. I know it sounds dramatic, but it's true.

A few days before graduation, I concussed myself. I cracked my head between a heavy door and the wall. [When I first told Alvin he started laughing because In Chinese, cracking your head between the doors is an expression calling someone stupid.] That following day I reconcussed myself, and the afternoon of that day I concussed myself again. The doctors ordered me to rest completely: no studying, no screens, no exercising. Suddenly, I had no hope but to stop. At first, I panicked.

I was excused from some of my finals, and I was left nothing to do. All I was told to do was to sleep and rest. I couldn't focus for a long time, I couldn't enjoy time under the sun, I couldn't read, I couldn't even exercise. And life was, for the first time in a while, unoccupied and blank. This blank schedule felt unsettling, and the thought of 'I could've been doing this if I hadn't been concussed…' repeated in my head.

But as those quiet days of recovery stretched on, in the stillness I began to see things differently. Since I practically couldn't do anything, I became best friends with my thoughts. Sometimes I would just lie on my bed, stare at the ceiling, think and reflect on life. At first, it felt strange—unproductive, even. But slowly, those moments of stillness began to feel less like wasted time and more like much-needed space. I realized how much I'd been running on autopilot, rushing from one task to the next without ever stopping to ask myself why. I had been so focused on crossing things off my to-do list that I lost sight of what was meaningful. I wasn't choosing my actions deliberately—I was just filling up every moment because I thought that's what success looked like. And in doing so, I wasn't giving myself the time to reflect on what truly mattered to me, whether it was the people I cared about, the goals that inspired me, or even the simple joys of life I'd been too busy to notice.



Photo by Yiru Wang ’25



Art by Sophie Forbes ’25

International House Chapel Talk

Amanda Meng '25

Where do I come from? Depending on who was asking, the answer usually varies. The simple answer is that I'm from Baltimore. But, if you want the slightly more complicated answer, I technically live in Lutherville-Timonium, a community sandwiched between the two suburban towns of Lutherville and Timonium 20 minutes north from Baltimore city.

Just as my hometown of Lutherville-Timonium cannot figure out where it belongs to, I seem to also fail in my search of home and belonging. Though I say I am from Maryland, that is not entirely complete. I was actually born in ShenZhen, a city in China next to Hong Kong. I grew up and attended a local public school there until I was 9, when I left for the US where my dad moved a year prior.

Earlier in 2016, my dad, faced with an opportunity to work overseas, left the comfort of his motherland for the US. He decided to move to a country where he barely knows the language, just so I could study in the American education system.

My dad left behind everything familiar so I could have new opportunities. But when I arrived, I felt like I had left behind everything familiar, too.

First couple months into my public elementary school, I was fascinated by the seemingly absurd amount of freedom I was given. Unlike the intense studying and rigorous testing, American kids with their strange little crackers called Lunchables seemed to have unlimited time to just play.

I stuck out like a sore thumb. My homework progressed from writing basic English sentences in China to writing paragraphs in my American elementary school. I still remember that I had to write a summary of my friend's homework because I couldn't even understand what the English reading was about. I had no idea what Thanksgiving was, I never had a pie in my life, and the whole idea of forks and knives even confused me.

It was then that I became obsessed with the idea of "looking normal," whatever that meant to 9-year-old Amanda. I threw away all of my fun colorful clothes that I brought across the world with me, and turned to the greys, blacks, and navy blues in an effort to blend in. I started talking less often, as I was scared that people would point out my accent and my incorrect grammar.

As I intentionally distanced myself with my past, I found myself living in between a rift of two different lives, separated by my two names.

In the States I used the name Amanda, a name that was picked by my dad who was the reason I was able to live and study in America. And there was my legal name 奕汐, meaning energetic tide, which was picked by my mother after her insistence of having me inherit her last name instead of my dad's. My Chinese name reminded me of my home in China, where my mom still lives. The name Amanda represented everything I desired to become, to look "American." Going by the name Amanda meant that I didn't need to bother with people who didn't know how to pronounce my name.

As Amanda became the name that everyone used, 奕汐 seemed like something that didn't belong to me anymore. My name on the passport seemed like a stranger's. I was confused between the two worlds. I can't seem to derive a sense of belonging in American culture, while also feeling disconnected to my Chinese ethnicity.

My sophomore year of St. Andrew's I was ready to accept my confusion. Perhaps this was the way it was and there was nothing I could do to change. I must always live in the state of duality, torn in between the two distinct parts of my past. However, this all changed when I got to know my two new roommates at the time, Emma and Jules.

Move-in day of my sophomore year, I came armed with my bucket of Chinese snacks including but not limited to duck neck, salt-baked chicken, and fish sticks.

Even though I have felt more and more disconnected to my culture, Chinese food was something that I never left behind. Initially, I was worried that they might find my snacks unusual, remembering the faces of disgust I have endured while I opened my eclectic array of snacks in middle school.

However, hunger has a remarkable way of bringing people together. Whenever asked about what I was eating, their excitement and interest was always a pleasant surprise. Soon, the curious nibbles became a monthly event that Jules called “exploring Amanda’s snack bin” to find whatever goodies that were lying around.

In the midst of all of the sampling, we eventually settled on a favorite: the spicy vegan beef tripe which Emma called “fire” as both of my roommates immediately reached for the water after devouring the spicy snack. Sitting cross-legged on the floor and sharing fire became one of my favorite moments. These snack sessions grew into something more—opportunities to share our stories, laugh at our inside jokes, and confide in each other about the challenges we faced. What started as a simple craving turned into a ritual that strengthened our bond and created a safe space to connect. Through sharing fire, I found a sense of belonging, for we, as a room, thrived because we all made it a priority to understand each other.

I have now lived in the US for the same amount of time as I have in Shenzhen. This coming August, I will have the choice of finally becoming a citizen.

But, what does it even mean?

And while reflecting on this sentiment, I stumbled across a picture of a 9-year-old me, just out of swim practice, shoving a cupcake in her face while wearing her favorite rainbow shorts. Behind the picture was a younger me, still unsure and struggling to figure out what this new world meant to her. Surprisingly, 9 years later, my first reaction to that picture was "Wow I look so American." Though I don't fully understand why I reacted that way, I realized that belonging here means the very opposite of escaping my culture. It was about embracing all of it.

I have spent the past 9 years of my life in pursuit of a very specific notion about fitting in. A notion filled with Thanksgiving gatherings, Easter, and peanut butter and jelly sandwiches. I always thought that blending in meant that I had to inevitably leave some part of me behind. However, perhaps belonging doesn't not take from what I have, but rather adds to my story.

America is not a nation, it is a state of existence. A nation is a group of people sharing a common culture, history, or identity. However, Americans don't always share a common story. We are a crockpot of all stories and perspectives.

I have an overdue thank you to Emma and Jules, my juniors on Mein, my study room, the faculty, and the people who I love and care about in this community. Here, at St. Andrew's, I felt understood for who I am. Perhaps that is also the beauty of American education values, having the freedom to be who I am and to pursue what I am passionate about.

At a fundamental level, a sense of belonging is a universal desire to understand and to be understood. I have found belonging through embracing who I am and who I was.

And therefore, we must not be afraid of embracing who we are.

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